anointing the late J. Jayalalithaa as 'eternal general secretary'—he hopes to turn the AIADMK back to a single boss party. Rule 20 of the party constitution vests the general secretary with sweeping powers, including nominating and dismissing office-bearers and initiating disciplinary proceedings. Anyone challenging his actions automatically loses primary membership of the party.

But EPS's attempts to take over as top boss suffered a setback when a bench of the Madras High Court, in an unprecedented pre-dawn sitting at the home of a judge, passed orders at 4.30 am, hours before the general council meeting, restraining party leaders from taking any decision against the OPS challenge. Another council meeting has been fixed for July 11 now to clear the way for EPS. On June 27, as OPS was touring the southern districts where he enjoys great public support, 65 of the 74 council members gathered at the party office in Chennai under presidium chairman Tamil Magan Hussain to decide on severing ties with him. Stripping him of the key post of AIADMK treasurer and other far-reaching decisions will be announced at the July 11 meeting, says senior leader and ex-minister D. Jayakumar, describing OPS as "a symbol of betrayal".

The AIADMK twin engine era has come to an end, with EPS soon to become the all-powerful general secretary. But OPS won't go down without a fight

Since the passing of Jayalalithaa in 2016, the AIADMK has struggled with factionalism and feuding. She had made OPS the stand-in chief minister twice when she had to step down following court convictions. In the days before she died, he stepped in to take charge again. But Jayalalithaa's close aide V.K. Sasikala, who took over the party after her death, had other plans. She sacked OPS when he rebelled against her.

Sasikala's hopes of becoming CM too came unstuck within months after her conviction in corruption cases. This did not deter her, though. Before leaving for jail, she made EPS the chief minister.

Initially, OPS and EPS were daggers drawn but realpolitik compelled them to join hands and expel Sasikala from the party. In an extraordinary power-sharing arrangement, EPS, as chief minister, made OPS his deputy in governance. The roles were reversed in the party with OPS becoming the AIADMK coordinator and EPS joint coordinator.

All was well with this arrangement until the AIADMK lost the election in 2021. The façade of unity was over but in December last, the two were elected to their respective party posts with the support of all primary members.

EPS senses that the time is now right to take control of the AIADMK. His priority now will be to take charge as gensec first and then, in one fell swoop, excise both OPS and the spectre of Sasikala from the AIADMK. Beyond that, EPS has to rebuild the party and win back the principal opposition space the AIADMK has yielded to the BJP and its state president K. Annamalai, who have been targeting the DMK government on its performance.

A stumbling block for the AIADMK is the lack of an iconic leader like founding member M.G. Ramachandran (MGR) or Jayalalithaa, who the legions of adulatory activists can look up to. On available evidence, EPS seems unequal to the task when compared to his charismatic predecessors but the manner in which he has marginalised OPS and kept Sasikala out of the running is proof that he could be a long-term player. Of course, if they get together (their common Mukkalothore Thevar community cohort is a strong binding force), the coronation of EPS as general secretary may lead to a north-south divide of the AIADMK in Tamil Nadu. ■

WESTERN GHATS

AGHAST

By Jeemon Jacob

It's one of the richest biodiversity hotspots on the planet, with even new species being discovered by biologists practically every other year. But Kerala's Ghat section is no pristine rainforest untouched by human hand. All along its north-south stretch, its edges have been progressively eaten up by rubber plantations, hotels and resorts and the sort of plain human habitation that Kerala is dense with. No wonder the June 3 Supreme Court ruling on a 1 km buffer zone for India's protected forests saw that part of Kerala erupt in public protests. Farmers' organisations in many of the 14 districts are up in arms. So are the state's political parties, as well as the influential Catholic church.

A three-judge bench had originally pronounced the judgement on a petition seeking protection of forest lands in the Nilgiris district of Tamil Nadu, but then decided to extend it to the rest of the country. The judgement referenced the guidelines on buffer zones issued in 2011 by the ministry of environment, forest and climate change (MoEF&CC).

In Kerala, it's only a minority—led by academics and green activists—that believes the SC's stand is a positive outcome. They feel the Western Ghats, which fringes the state along its eastern flank, is in peril and that Kerala has failed to learn from the consecutive floods since 2018. Erratic monsoons, ascribed to climate change, are bringing unpredictable, intense downpours. And soil piping, a phenomenon where subsoil erosion causes underground tunnels to be formed and then leads to subsidence, sees massive landslides every year in the hills. The environmentalists believe politicians have taken an opportunistic stand to appease their vote banks while the Church is out to protect its own and the flock's